

While and during

Learner workbook

Connect activities that overlap in time.

Understand the distinction

While commonly introduces a clause: while I was cooking. During is a preposition followed by a noun phrase: during dinner. Both can locate something within another period or event.

While cooking is also possible when the understood subject is clear. While does not require a continuous tense in every context: while I am away is natural. During does not say how long an action lasted; use for with a duration.

Compare the patterns

WHILE + CLAUSE

The phone rang while I was cooking.

A subject and verb follow while.

DURING + NOUN

The phone rang during dinner.

Dinner names the event.

FOR + DURATION

We talked for an hour.

An hour measures the duration.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. I took notes ___ the meeting.

2. Correct this: During I was reading, it began to rain.

3. Which means a duration: during the lesson or for an hour?

Use it in your own life

Describe an interruption during an activity.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. during

The meeting is a noun phrase.

2. While I was reading, it began to rain.

I was reading is a clause.

3. for an hour

During identifies the surrounding event; for gives the length.

One possible response

A friend called while I was making lunch.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-04.html